

4. After the Uprising of the Six Frontier Garrisons, China's Feudalization Process Reached Its Zenith

With the "second southward descent" of the Xianbei people, the degree of feudalization (封建化) in Northern China reached its historical zenith, which was naturally true from a nationwide perspective as well. This high degree of feudalization was most concentratedly reflected in the process of military confrontation between the Western Wei and Eastern Wei regimes.

Gao Huan (高欢), as the paramount minister of Eastern Wei and the founder of the Northern Qi regime, always exudes a highly unique and rare personal charisma in Chinese historical narratives. However, once we discard this particularized "Great Man theory of history" (英雄史观) and view him instead as one of the primary political leaders and participants during the zenith of China's feudalization, it is not difficult to realize that what ultimately determined his behavior was not his personality, but the social reality of that era.

For example, in the Battle of Shayuan (沙苑之战) and its associated military operations, Gao Huan suffered a disastrous defeat against Yuwen Tai (宇文泰). Consequently, he decided to resign from the post of Chancellor (Chengxiang / 丞相). Despite Emperor Xiaojing, Yuan Shanjian (孝静帝元善见) urging him to stay, Gao Huan resolutely resigned the chancellorship. When Chinese historiography explains this event, it often considers it primarily from the perspective of Gao Huan's personal character.

Yet, we can easily observe a fundamental political principle: the strength or weakness of political power solely concerns the nature of its source of power, and has absolutely nothing to do with empty titles.

We can consider two earlier examples. Cao Cao (曹操), the founder of the Cao Wei regime, certainly suffered no shortage of defeats in his lifetime. In hindsight, his defeats at Chibi (Red Cliffs) and Hanzhong altered the geopolitical landscape under heaven; yet, even following such disastrous defeats, he did not resign his chancellorship. This was because a substantial portion of Cao Cao's ruling power derived from the signboard of being the Chancellor of the Han Empire. The position of Han Chancellor enabled him to recruit more aristocratic clans (Shizu / 士族) to serve him, thereby enhancing the legitimacy of his rule and gaining a moral advantage over his enemies.

Shortly thereafter, however, Zhuge Liang (诸葛亮), the Chancellor of the Shu Han regime, resolutely resigned his chancellorship after the failure of his first Northern Expedition (北伐). Upon careful consideration of this matter, we will find that Zhuge Liang was absolutely not throwing in the towel; rather, he believed that the source of his power had nothing to do with the office of Chancellor itself.

The reason Zhuge Liang was able to monopolize state administration—especially possessing the final say in personnel matters—was fundamentally derived from the deathbed entrustment (Tuogu / 托孤) by the late Emperor Liu Bei. Secondly, it stemmed from his undisputed status as the leader of the Jingzhou literati residing in Shu after the loss of Jingzhou itself. Since this was the case, resigning the chancellorship would neither affect his actual power (as he continued to "execute the duties of the Chancellor") nor impact the grand enterprise of the Northern Expeditions. Thus, there was no reason not to put on such a political performance.

When we observe Gao Huan himself, the situation differs from the other two. As Chancellor, Gao Huan actually lived apart from Emperor Xiaojing; the emperor resided in Ye (邺城), while Gao Huan was based in Jinyang (晋阳). At first glance, this situation somewhat resembles the dynamic

between the Japanese Emperor's court and the Shogunate (幕府) established by the samurai. But upon closer inspection, the resemblance is even more striking.

An important piece of evidence is his establishment of the "Emigrant Provinces" (Qiaozhou / 侨州). Once Gao Huan finalized Jinyang as his residence, he quickly settled the Xianbei clans who had moved south from the Six Garrisons into the Shanxi region, organizing them into "Emigrant Provinces" that reported directly to him rather than being under the jurisdiction of the Eastern Wei court. In reality, these became the "Tenryō" (天领 - Shogunal Demesne) of the "Shogun."

Furthermore, Gao Huan's key generals—for instance, the most famous among them, Hou Jing (侯景)—not only guarded specific regions for long periods but also possessed their own tribal retinues. In fact, if we acknowledge that Gao Huan was not merely the Chancellor of the Eastern Wei regime, but also the supreme feudal lord (最高封建领主) recognized by his similarly feudalized (封建化) subordinate generals, then the office of Chancellor had absolutely nothing to do with the source of his power.

This is much like how a Shogun who dominates the realm could, of course, accept the title of Minister of the Left (Sadaijin / 左大臣) within the Japanese imperial system. But even if he did not hold that post and was merely a Middle Captain of the Right Guards (Ukonoe no Chūjō / 右近卫中将), who would dare refuse to acknowledge his power? Precisely because the position of Chancellor itself was equivalent to a court office held by a Shogun—having no bearing on the source of his power—Gao Huan naturally possessed the conditions to make such a political gesture.

More direct and abundant evidence is reflected in the military campaigns between Eastern Wei and Western Wei. If we were to view the armies of these two states as imperial forces uniformly provisioned with pay and rations by the court—much like the armed forces of China before or after this period—we would inevitably find some behaviors of the people at that time utterly bizarre. However, if we view them as coalition armies summoned by feudal lords according to feudal obligations—much like certain military campaigns in the European Middle Ages—then many issues make perfect sense.

Precisely because under a feudal system (封建制度), even the supreme lord lacks the absolute power of a despotic monarch (专制君主)—being merely the highest-ranking among lords—his subordinate lords have greater confidence to say: "Our interests are not the same as yours." Within a feudal system, for a king under an emperor's rule, he certainly does not always wish for the emperor to win battles, because the expansion of the emperor's power and influence is highly likely to threaten his own fiefdom. Interestingly, after Gao Huan's army achieved a decisive victory over Yuwen Tai at the Battle of Mangshan (邙山之战), the situation indeed presented an opportunity to strike directly into Guanzhong to unify the North. Yet, his generals expressed opposition, causing the victory to slip away just like that.

At the same time, the unfolding of pitched battles was heavily imbued with feudal characteristics (封建特征). It might initially begin as mutual probing between border lords of the two countries, escalating into military actions. Subsequently, the respective supreme lords would enter the fray leading their direct troops and summon other regional lords subordinate to them to dispatch troops in assistance, ultimately evolving into an all-out war. Gao Ang (高昂) and Hou Jing's siege of Dugu Xin (独孤信), which triggered a massive battle between Yuwen Tai and Gao Huan, serves as an excellent example (the Battle of Heqiao, 538 CE).

During other periods in China, it is extremely difficult to imagine that generals of a centralized state's court—even frontier generals—could possess such massive autonomy and interact with the

central government in such a manner. This similarly explains why Gao Huan always pardoned generals who committed severe blunders, such as Gao Yongle and Peng Le. Once we recognize that these subordinate generals of Gao Huan essentially possessed the characteristics of feudal lords, it becomes very easy to understand that it was absolutely impossible for him to easily remove his vassals (封臣) like a despotic monarch. Because this is not merely a matter of retracting power granted by the central government to an individual; it would also incite severe suspicion among his other vassals.

A final, highly fascinating example is that, although Gao Huan himself held command in Jinyang, his legitimate eldest son Gao Cheng (高澄) acted as the "Grand Commander of the Capital Region" (京畿大都督) in Ye to surveil the court. This situation strongly calls to mind the political landscape of the early Kamakura Shogunate (鎌仓幕府) in Japan. When Hōjō Yoshitoki (北条义时) monopolized power in Kamakura as the Regent (Shikken / 执权) of the Shogunate, he similarly had his heir, Hōjō Yasutoki (北条泰时), serve as the Rokuhara Tandai (六波罗探题) in Kyoto to surveil the imperial court on behalf of the Shogunate.

This astonishing similarity not only further implies the possibility of the existence of a "Gao Shogunate" (高氏幕府) back then, but also perhaps reveals a commonality in early feudal politics influenced by the Chinese system.

In reality, there is an overwhelming abundance of evidence in the historical records of this period supporting the fact that Northern China had already undergone intense feudalization (封建化) following the uprising of the Six Frontier Garrisons. Beyond political behavior, people's political concepts were also severely impacted.

Take the standard procedure of usurpation by paramount ministers in China as an example. There are ten extant "Edicts of the Nine Bestowals" (Jiuxi Wen / 九锡文) preserved in our country's history. With the exception of the one where Emperor Wen of Wei, Cao Pi (魏文帝曹丕) enfeoffed Sun Quan (孙权) as the King of Wu, the other nine bestowals of the Nine Honors were all preparatory steps prior to usurpation by a paramount minister.

Under the ideology of a Chinese bureaucratic state (官僚国家), if the emperor were to directly hand over the Mandate of Heaven to the usurper via formal abdication (Shanrang / 禅让), it would appear extremely abrupt to the people. Therefore, the Edicts of the Nine Bestowals served a specific function: before usurping the throne, the paramount minister first obtained partial co-rulership of the realm through a legitimate method.

The writing requirements for the Edicts of the Nine Bestowals reflected this by following a general rule: first narrating the severe hardships facing the state's destiny, and then emphasizing the military achievements of the paramount minister in "saving and sustaining the state" (Kuangfu Sheji / 匡扶社稷). After the emperor expressed deep shame in the face of the minister's monumental merits, he would grant the minister a portion of the state's territory—usually ten to thirty commanderies (Jun / 郡)—enfeoff the minister as a Duke or King with hereditary fiefdoms, and grant a series of ceremonial privileges.

The ideology behind this was the concept of "King's Land, King's People" (王土-王民). Even though China nominally recognized the private ownership of land since the Qin dynasty, the concept of private property under a bureaucratic system (官僚体制) was destined to be extremely fragile. From the emperor's perspective, the land of his subjects was still his own land; there was no reason it absolutely could not be reclaimed. Therefore, even if a paramount minister was already de facto ruling the state, he still needed a legal procedure to first become the owner of a portion of the realm,

and subsequently the owner of the entire realm. The Edicts of the Nine Bestowals for Cao Cao, Sima Zhao, Liu Yu, Xiao Daocheng, Xiao Yan, Chen Baxian, Yang Jian, and Li Yuan all contained content regarding the granting of fiefdoms.

The sole exception is the edict wherein Emperor Wenxuan of Northern Qi, Gao Yang (北齐文宣皇帝高洋), received the Nine Bestowals from Emperor Xiaojing, Yuan Shanjian (孝静帝元善见), which contained no mention of granting a fiefdom. This phenomenon highly likely reflects the development of feudalized consciousness in Eastern Wei society. If the emperor himself was no longer viewed as the owner of all land under heaven, and rulers of different ranks could all possess their own hereditary territories, then there was indeed no need to specifically emphasize the granting of fiefdoms in the Edict of the Nine Bestowals. The Gao family's regime in Jinyang was perhaps already universally regarded as a feudal shogunate back then, to the point that everyone felt it unnecessary to make a superfluous move to affirm the legitimacy of the Gao family's land ownership.

The Book of Wei (《魏书》) is a biographical dynastic history compiled by the historian Wei Shou (魏收) after the establishment of Northern Qi, recording nearly two centuries of history of the Northern Wei Dynasty (including Eastern Wei). Precisely because no scholar can escape the influence of their era, the Book of Wei actually leaves behind an extremely fascinating perspective for later generations, allowing us to observe Northern Qi society from a specific angle.

For instance, the Book of Wei does not consider Southern Qi (南齐) and Southern Liang (南梁) to be two separate regimes; rather, it views them as a single regime that first called itself "Qi" and later, after an internal imperial strife, called itself "Liang." This perspective reflects a feudalized consciousness—namely, "who rules which land." Wei Shou believed that since Xiao Yan (萧衍) also belonged to the Lanling Xiao clan (兰陵萧氏), the fact that the Xiao clan ruled Southern China had not changed (though, from the Northern dynasties' perspective, it was an illegal rule, naturally). Thus, it inherently remained merely another phase of the "Xiao Dynasty."

During the Hou Jing Rebellion (侯景之乱), when Gao Cheng (高澄) decided to seize the opportunity to launch an expedition against the South, Murong Shaozong (慕容绍宗) drafted a call to arms (Xiwen / 檄文) for him, bluntly stating: "Since the pseudo-Jin, the Liu and Xiao have wrought chaos." He claimed that Xiao Yan was not only a usurping, rebellious minister, but because Southern Qi and Southern Liang belonged to the same royal house, Xiao Yan was also a thief who slaughtered his own kin and corrupted human morality (all found within the Biography of the Island Barbarian Xiao Yan / 《岛夷萧衍传》).

This understanding vastly differs from how later Chinese viewed the Southern Dynasties. In the eyes of the Chinese Empire under a bureaucratic system, no matter how hypocritical the abdication was, Xiao Yan indeed received the Mandate of Heaven and legal orthodoxy from Xiao Baorong (萧宝融) through a formally legal process, established a new dynastic title, and changed the era name. Therefore, Liang and Qi were naturally two completely different dynasties; it was merely that their rulers both hailed from the Lanling Xiao clan.

In contrast, in medieval Europe, people naturally divided dynasties based on families according to feudal consciousness. Although it was all the Holy Roman Empire, rule by different families divided it into different dynasties; the same view applied to Byzantium. Therefore, an observer can easily discover how massive a discrepancy this is compared to the transition between Qi and Liang—where the ruling family remained unchanged yet later generations viewed them as two separate dynasties. One can also sense exactly which side the perspective of northern intellectuals leaned toward during the Wei-Qi period. As for other evidence, it will not be further detailed here.

中文原文：

4，六镇起义之后中国的封建化进程达到顶点

随着鲜卑人的“第二次南下”，中国北方的封建化程度达到了历史顶峰，当然从全国范围看也是如此。这种高度的封建化集中体现在西魏和东魏政权的军事对峙过程中。高欢，作为东魏的权臣和北齐政权的奠基人，其在中国总让人感受到一种极为特殊和难得的人格魅力。但是我们一旦抛弃这种特质化的英雄史观，而将其视为中国在封建化顶点年代的一个最主要的政治领袖和参与者，就不难意识到决定其行为的归根到底不是其性格，而是当年的社会现实。例如，在沙苑之战及其附属军事行动中，高欢面对宇文泰收获了一场惨败，于是决定辞去丞相一职，尽管孝静帝元善见予以挽留，但是高欢还是坚决辞掉了丞相。中国的史学界解释这件事情的时候，更多是从高欢个人的性格来进行考虑。但是我们很容易注意到这样一个政治上的原则，那就是政治权力的强弱只关乎其权力来源的情况，而与虚名无关。我们可以考虑两个更早的例子，曹魏政权的奠基人曹操在一生中同样没少吃败仗，从事后来看，在赤壁和汉中的失败都改变了天下的格局，但是即使是这样的惨败他也没有辞掉丞相一职。这是因为曹操本人统治的权力有相当程度上来自汉帝国丞相的这个招牌，汉朝丞相的职务使他能够招揽更多的士族为其服务，增强自己统治的合法性，并且获得对敌人道义上的优势。而其后不久蜀汉政权的丞相诸葛亮，在最初的北伐失败之后却坚决辞掉了丞相一职，我们仔细考虑这件事就会发现，诸葛亮绝对不是撂挑子不干，而是认为其权力来源与丞相这个职务并没有关系。诸葛亮之所以能够总揽国家行政，特别是在人事上具有拍板的权力，本身是来源于先主刘备的托孤，其次则是在丧失荆州之后作为蜀地的荆州士人领袖没有争议的地位。既然如此，辞掉丞相既不会影响他本人的权力（仍行丞相事），也不会影响北伐大业，那么就没有理由不进行这样一个政治上的表演。

当我们观察高欢本人，情况则又与两者不同，高欢作为丞相实际上与孝静帝分居两地，皇帝本人在邺城，而高欢在晋阳。这种局面乍看起来有一点像日本天皇的朝廷与武士所建立的幕府，但是仔细看起来就更像了。一个重要的证据就是他所设立的“侨州”，当高欢确定晋阳作为他的居所之后，他很快将六镇南下的鲜卑氏族安置在山西地区，并把它们编入直属于自己而非受东魏朝廷管辖的“侨州”，这在事实上成为了“幕府将军”的“天领”。而高欢的重要部将，例如最有名的侯景不但也长期镇守一方而且同样拥有自己的部众。实际上，假如我们承认高欢不仅仅是东魏政权的丞相，也是他同样封建化的手下将领所认可的最高封建领主，那么丞相一个职务就完全不关乎其权力来源。这就好比一个坐拥天下的幕府将军在日本的体制内当然可以拜领朝廷的左大臣，但是即使他不担任左大臣而仅仅是一个右近卫中将，又有谁敢不承认他的权力呢？正是因为丞相一职本身相当于幕府将军所领的朝廷官职，既然无关于权力来源，那么高欢自然有了做姿态的条件。更直接也更多的证据体现在东魏和西魏之间的军事行动中，如果将当时两国的军队视为由朝廷统一发放军饷粮草的官军，就像中国之前或者之后的武装一样，那么必然对当时人的一些行为感到十分的稀奇古怪。但是如果将其视为封建领主依照封建义务所征召来的联军，像欧洲中世纪的一些军事行动一样，那么很多问题就解释得通了。正是因为封建制度下，即使是最高领主，也没有专制君主那样绝对的权力，其不过是领主中级别最高的一个，那么他的下属领主就更有底气去说：我们的利益跟您并不一样。在封建体制中对于一个皇帝治下的国王来说，他肯定是不总希望皇帝打胜仗的，因为皇帝权势的扩大很可能会威胁到自己的领地。有意思的是，高欢的军队在邙山之战中对宇文泰取得决定性的大胜之后，在形势上看确实有机会直捣关中以统一北方，但其将领却表达了反对，使得胜利这样溜走了。

同时会战的展开也极具封建特色，最开始可能是两国边境领主的互相试探，然后升级为军事行动，紧接着各自的封军也率领直属部队下场，并且召集其他地方隶属于自己的领主出兵协助，最终演化成全面战争。高昂和侯景包围独孤信，引起宇文泰和高欢双方的大战就是一个非常好的例子（河桥之战，538年）。在中国其他时期，很难想象集权国家朝廷的将领，哪怕是边将能有这么大的自主权，并且以如此方式与中央互动。这同样也解释为什么高欢总是对犯下严重错误的将领加以宽宥，例如高永乐和彭乐，一旦我们认为高欢的这些手下将领本质上也具有封建领主的特征，那么就很容易理解他绝对不可能像一

个专制君主一样轻松地拿掉自己的封臣，因为这不仅仅是收回一个人从中央所获权力的问题，并且引起其他封臣的严重怀疑。最后一个非常有趣的例子是，尽管高欢本人在晋阳坐镇，他的嫡长子高澄却作为“京畿大都督”在邺城监视朝廷。这种局面非常让人联想到日本镰仓幕府早期的政治形势，当北条义时作为幕府的执权在镰仓揽有大权的时候，他同样让自己的继承人北条泰时在京都担任“六波罗探题”为幕府监视朝廷。这种惊人的相似性不但进一步暗示“高氏幕府”在当年存在的可能性，而且也可能给出了受中国体制影响的封建早期政治的一种共性。

实际上，在这个时期的史料中支持六镇起义之后北方已经剧烈封建化的证据实在太多，除了政治行为，人们的政治观念也受到了冲击。就拿中国权臣篡位的一般流程来说吧！我国历史上留存下的“九锡文”共有十篇，除了魏文帝曹丕册封孙权为吴王的一篇以外，其余九次加九锡全部都是权臣篡位前的准备步骤。在中国官僚国家的意识形态下，皇帝如果直接把天命通过禅让交给篡位者，这在人们看来是极为突兀的。因此九锡文承担有这样一种功能，在篡位之前，权臣先通过一种具有合法性的方式获得天下的部分共治权。这体现在九锡文的书写上的要求就是在按照一般规则首先叙述国运艰难，然后强调权臣匡扶社稷的武功，皇帝在权臣的功勋面前感到非常惭愧之后，授予权臣国家的一部分领土，一般是十到三十个郡，将权臣封为有世袭领地的公或者王，并且给予一系列礼仪上的优待。这背后的意识形态就是一种“王土-王民”思想，哪怕秦以来中国名义上承认土地私有，但是官僚体制下私有财产观念注定是非常薄弱的。在皇帝看来，自己臣民的土地依然是自己的土地，没有什么一定不能收回的理由。因此哪怕权臣已经事实上在统治国家，他仍然需要一个程序合法地成为部分天下所有者，然后再成为整个天下的所有者，曹操、司马昭、刘裕、萧道成、萧衍、陈霸先、杨坚、李渊这八个人的九锡文都有赐予封土的内容。唯独北齐文宣帝高洋从孝静帝元善见那里获九锡的策文中没有赐予封土的内容。这种现象很有可能反映了东魏社会封建化意识的发展，如果皇帝本身就不被视为天底下所有土地的拥有者，不同等级的统治者都可以拥有属于自己的世袭领土，那么确实没有必要在九锡文中专门强调封土的赐予。高氏在晋阳的政权在当年或许已经被普遍被视为一个封建幕府，以至于人人都觉得没有必要多此一举来肯定高氏拥有土地的正当性。

《魏书》是北齐建立后由史学家魏收所编写的纪传体断代史，记录了北魏王朝（包括东魏）近两个世纪的历史。正是因为任何学者都没办法摆脱他所处时代的影响，《魏书》实际上为后人留下了一个非常有趣的视角，让我们能从一个侧面观察北齐社会。例如，《魏书》并不认为南齐和南梁是两个政权，而是一个政权先自称为“齐”，后来经过一场皇室内乱之后自称为“梁”。这种看法反映了一种封建化的意识，即“何人治何土”，魏收认为，既然萧衍也属于兰陵萧氏，那么萧氏统治中国南方这一点就没有发生变化（当然在北朝看来是非法统治），自然而然的还属于“萧氏王朝”另一阶段。侯景之乱时高澄决定趁势讨伐南方，慕容绍宗为之做檄文，直言道“伪晋以来，刘萧作乱”，并声称萧衍不仅仅是一个篡位的逆臣，而且南齐和南梁是一个皇室，所以萧衍还是屠杀亲族的败坏人伦之贼（皆在《岛夷萧衍传》中）。这种认识就与之后中国人对于南朝的认识大为不同，对官僚制下的中华帝国看来，无论禅让是多么虚伪，但是萧衍的确从萧宝融那里通过一个形式上合法的流程接过了天命和法统，并且建号改元，因此梁和齐自然是两个不同的王朝，只不过其统治者都出于兰陵萧氏罢了。而在中世纪的欧洲，人们自然地依照封建意识去按家族划分王朝，尽管都是神圣罗马帝国，但是不同的家族统治则将其划分为不同的朝代，对拜占庭的看法也是如此。所以观察者可以轻易地发现这与齐梁易代中统治家族没有改变，却被后世视为两个王朝有多大的差距，也能够感受到在魏齐时期北方知识分子的视角究竟偏向于哪一方。至于其他的证据，这里就不再赘述了。